DRUGS · VERTIGO AND MÉNIÈRE'S DISEASE

Benzodiazepines for vertigo

Benzodiazepines such as diazepam enhance GABA-mediated inhibition, including in the vestibular nuclei, and reduce the anxiety that accompanies severe vertigo. They can help in the first day or two of a violent acute vestibular attack, but they impair compensation, cause sedation and falls, and lead to dependence. They have little place in chronic dizziness.

1 CHAPTER ONE At a glance

The drugs on one page.

1.1 Summary

BENZODIAZEPINES FOR VERTIGO

	SUMMARY
Agents	Diazepam (long-acting); lorazepam (shorter-acting); clonazepam (sometimes in persistent postural-perceptual dizziness or vestibular paroxysmia alternatives)
How they work	Positive allosteric modulators of the GABA-A receptor; vestibular suppression and anxiolysis
ENT uses	Severe acute vertigo for 1 to 3 days when other sedatives are insufficient; acute anxiety associated with vertigo
Adult dose	Diazepam 2 to 5 mg up to three times daily for a few days
Avoid	Respiratory depression, sleep apnoea, myasthenia, severe hepatic impairment; the elderly where possible

2 CHAPTER TWO Using them in ENT

Indications.

2.1 Acute vertigo

Reserve for the most distressing first days of an attack; combine with an antiemetic and stop as soon as possible. Persistent dizziness after an acute vestibular event (persistent postural-perceptual dizziness) is better treated with vestibular rehabilitation, cognitive behavioural therapy and SSRIs or SNRIs than with benzodiazepines.

3 CHAPTER THREE Safety

What goes wrong.

3.1 Adverse effects

Sedation, ataxia, falls, confusion; respiratory depression with opioids; tolerance and dependence after 2 to 4 weeks; withdrawal symptoms. In patients with obstructive sleep apnoea, they worsen nocturnal apnoea.

3.2 Interactions

Opioids (fatal respiratory depression), alcohol, other sedatives; CYP3A4 inhibitors raise diazepam levels.

4 CHAPTER FOUR For the examination

What the examiner wants to hear.

4.1 Viva essentials

WHAT THE EXAMINER IS LOOKING FOR

- Why benzodiazepines delay vestibular compensation.

- The dangers in the elderly and in sleep apnoea.

4.2 Common pitfalls

COMMON PITFALLS

- Long-term benzodiazepines for chronic dizziness.
- Combining with opioids after surgery in a patient with sleep apnoea.

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